

A half marathon is built in 12 weeks, mostly at easy pace

Pick a half marathon, then count back 12 weeks: that Monday starts week 1. 13.1 miles is saved up three deposits a week and withdrawn once. The whole plan is the discipline of running slow, on schedule, so you can race fast once.

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01 Your week

Three runs, two strength days, two rest days. Same shape every week.

- **3 runs**, never back to back. Each one is a small deposit.
- **2 strength days** (work that builds you without pounding your legs). A scaled CrossFit class counts.
- **2 full rest days**, Monday and Friday. Rest is when the deposit clears.

12

Weeks from first run to race day

3 + 2 + 2

Runs, strength days, full rest days each week

10 mi

Longest single training run in the plan

02 The four runs

Four types, four jobs. Confusing them is the most common mistake.

- **Easy** (you can talk in full sentences). Most of your miles live here.
- **Tempo** (comfortably hard, about an hour of effort). Teaches you to clear fatigue while moving.
- **Race pace** (the pace you plan to hold on race day). Rehearsal, so it feels familiar, not brave.
- **Long**. Run it EASY. The distance is the workout.

03 The arc

A slow climb, a short breather, then a deliberate step back.

- Mileage starts near 17 and peaks near 22 in week 10.

- The long run climbs to 10 miles. No week jumps much.
- Cutback weeks are deliberate: a lighter week lets the previous month settle.
- The last two weeks taper. You cannot gain fitness in the final 10 days, only spend it early.

The long run at easy pace IS the plan. Everything else exists so you can finish it, recover, and do it again a mile longer.

04 The calendar

All 12 weeks, counted back from race day. Monday and Friday are always rest.

- Wednesday and Sunday are cross training, the strength and easy aerobic work that fills your two non running days.
- Weeks 6 and 9 (tinted) are cutbacks: no long run, optional short race or time trial. Week 11 starts the taper.
- Thursday rotates easy, race pace, tempo. Saturday is always the long run.
- Peak stays at week 10, 15 days out. A long run's fitness posts about two weeks later, so a 10 miler 8 days out delivers fatigue, not fitness.

WK	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
1	Rest	4 mi easy	Cross 30 min	3 mi run	Rest	6 mi long	Cross 30 min
2	Rest	4 mi easy	Cross 35 min	Tempo 30 min	Rest	6 mi long	Cross 35 min
3	Rest	5 mi easy	Cross 40 min	3 mi run	Rest	7 mi long	Cross 40 min
4	Rest	5 mi easy	Cross 45 min	4 mi pace	Rest	7 mi long	Cross 45 min
5	Rest	4 mi easy	Cross 50 min	Tempo 40 min	Rest	8 mi long	Cross 50 min
6	Rest	4 mi easy	Cross 30 min	3 mi run	Rest	Rest	5K race, or a time trial
7	Rest	6 mi easy	Cross 50 min	5 mi pace	Rest	9 mi long	Cross 50 min
8	Rest	6 mi easy	Cross 50 min	Tempo 50 min	Rest	9 mi long	Cross 50 min
9	Rest	4 mi easy	Cross 30 min	3 mi run	Rest	Rest	10K race, or a time trial
10	Rest	6 mi easy	Cross 60 min	6 mi pace	Rest	10 mi long	Cross 60 min
11	Rest	5 mi easy	Cross 45 min	Tempo 40 min	Rest	7 mi long	Cross 40 min
12	Rest	4 mi easy	Cross 30 min	3 mi run	Rest	Rest	HALF MARATHON

05 Strength

Two short sessions protect the running. Five slots, all swappable.

- **Push:** bench press (or dumbbell press, or pushups).
- **Squat:** goblet squat (or back squat, or lunges).
- **Hinge:** trap bar deadlift or dumbbell RDL (hips back, soft knees). No barbell deadlift.
- **Pull:** one arm row (or cable row, or assisted pullups).

- **Calves and core:** calf raises plus a plank. For a runner this is injury insurance, not vanity. Keep heavy legs away from Saturday's long run. Never skip the calf slot.

06 Fuel

General guidance, not a prescription.

- **Under an hour:** nothing needed. Water.
- **Tempo and pace days:** about 25g of carbs (a banana, or toast with honey) 30 to 60 min before.
- **Long runs, 8 mi and up:** a carb meal 2 to 3 hours before, then 30 to 60g per hour (gel, chews, or sports drink) past 75 minutes. Rehearse it on long run days; never invent it on race day.
- **Race morning:** a familiar breakfast 3 hours out. Nothing new.
- **After every run:** protein plus carbs within the hour. The deposit posts during recovery.

07 The catch

More is not better. Extra withdrawals drain the account you are growing.

- Running the easy days hard is the classic failure. It steals from the long run and adds nothing.
- Extra training days stay genuinely light, and drop first when you feel run down.
- Heavy legs, poor sleep, or a rising resting heart rate mean take the rest day.
- Skipping a run costs less than forcing one. An injury closes the account for weeks.

BOTTOM LINE

**There are no emotions on the road. Poise on race day is manufactured in week 3.
Run the system, bank the deposits, and make one withdrawal.**

SOURCES & NOTE

Sources: Hal Higdon, Half Marathon 3 (HM3) training program, halhigdon.com; TrainingPeaks, Hal Higdon HM3 plan summary.

Educational, not medical or coaching advice. Structure follows Hal Higdon's HM3 program where stated; exercise selections and swaps are general guidance. Structure modified from HM3: week 11 taper revision, 2026-07-22.

Glossary

Cross training Aerobic work that spares your legs: cycling, swimming, or brisk walking.

Cutback week A deliberately lighter week that lets recent training settle in.

Taper The final drop in mileage before the race so you arrive fresh.

Trap bar A hexagonal bar you stand inside; lets you lift heavy with a more upright back.

RDL **Romanian deadlift** A hinge movement: hips travel back, knees stay soft, hamstrings load.
